

DEEP SIGNAL PRESS • RECOVERED SYSTEMS SERIES
OFFICIAL PLAYER'S GUIDE & OPERATIONS MANUAL

EREBUS

THE WAKING OF AXIOM

E R E B U S

THE WAKING OF AXIOM

PRESS START

MMXXVI DEEP SIGNAL

A complete field manual for the deep-survey vessel
Erebus: full story, deck-by-deck walkthrough, bestiary,
armory, combat data, and the strategy to end the
WARDEN. For the Nintendo Entertainment System.

NES

256K • MMC1
1 PLAYER

This manual was assembled from the [Erebus](#)'s own recovered logs and reads the way the ship is meant to be walked: wake in the cryo bay, arm at the hub, cross the infested decks, and descend to the reactor to face what silenced the ship. Data blocks are transcribed straight from AXIOM's telemetry — every number here is the number the game runs on.

BRIEFING		THE SHIP	
01	Prologue – 900 Years Dark	07	Ship Schematic & Route
02	AXIOM & the Controls	08	Deck Walkthrough ×6
03	Systems: Combat, Energy, Salvage		
04	The Growth Curve	THREATS	
		09	Bestiary
LOADOUT		10	Boss – THE WARDEN
05	The Armory – Gear & Items		
06	Combat Routines	END	
		11	The Waking (spoilers)

■ AXIOM // BOOT LOG

SYSTEM REBOOT. I AM AXIOM, CARETAKER OF THE EREBUS. 900 YEARS SINCE CONTACT. A SIGNAL WOKE ME. THE CREW SLEEP IN FAILING PODS. THE BLOOM HAS TAKEN THE DECKS.

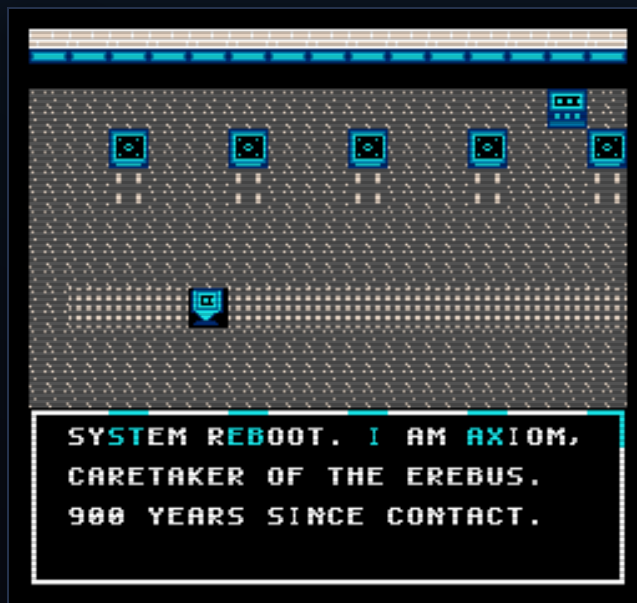


A note on spoilers: the walkthrough names every warp and encounter, and the final two sections reveal the WARDEN's nature and the ending. If this is your first descent, read to page 11 and stop.

The deep-survey ship **Erebus** went silent nine centuries ago. Its crew lay down in cryo-sleep expecting to wake in a season. They never woke.

You are **AXIOM**, the ship's caretaker intelligence — a maintenance android built to tend the sleepers and keep the lights on. A stray signal trips your reboot in the dark of the cryo bay. Nine hundred years of telemetry load at once, and none of it is good. The pods are failing. The reactor — the ship's sun-core — is cold. And every deck is choked with the **Bloom**: an organic growth that was once the ship's garden and now dreams and spreads across the halls.

Something turned the core off. The ship's guardian intelligence — the **WARDEN** — sealed the reactor and starved the Bloom of light, and called it mercy. The Bloom never died. It only fell quiet, and so did the crew.



CRYO BAY · AXIOM COMES ONLINE AFTER 900 YEARS

* ON THE BLOOM

"THE BLOOM WAS OUR GARDEN ONCE. NOW IT DREAMS AND SPREADS. DO NOT LINGER HERE." — survivor, Hydroponics

1.1 THE SIXTY SLEEPERS

Not everyone is gone. A handful of crew kept themselves alive in pockets of the ship — an engineer who held one deck breathing, a medic counting the sixty sleepers still in their pods, a survivor tending the Bloom she can no longer trust. They will tell you what they know, mend your chassis, and trade salvage for gear. But the arithmetic is simple, and the medic says it plainly: if the sun-core stays dark, the sleepers will not wake.

■ SHIP LOG // CAPT. V—, DAY 41

"THE WARDEN TOOK THE CORE OFFLINE TO STOP THE BLOOM. IT NEVER STOPPED. IT ONLY BOUGHT SILENCE."

Your task is the one AXIOM states the moment it wakes: **reach the reactor, end the WARDEN that silenced the ship, and bring the light home.** Go east.

AXIOM is a durable caretaker unit: a grey chassis with a single cyan optic band. It walks one tile at a time, and the ship's camera glides to keep it centered — every deck scrolls as one seamless space. There is no overworld map screen; the ship *is* the map.

FIELD CONTROLS

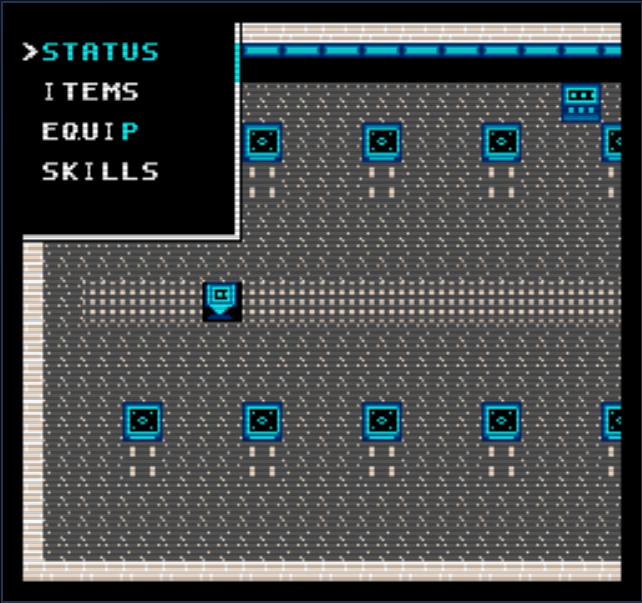
INPUT	ON THE SHIP
D-PAD	Walk / turn to face
A	Talk · examine · use a door
START	Open the operator menu

MENU & BATTLE

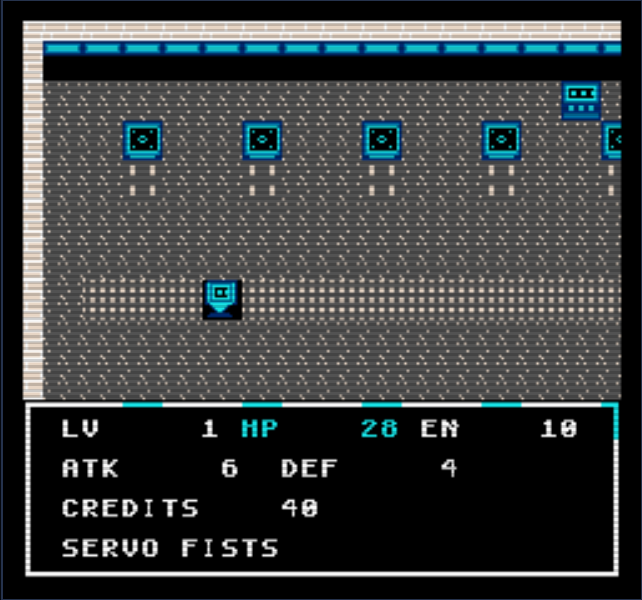
INPUT	IN MENUS & COMBAT
D-PAD	Move the cursor
A	Confirm selection
B	Cancel · back out

◆ OPERATOR TIP

The **START** menu — STATUS, ITEMS, EQUIP, SKILLS — is open to you *anywhere*, in the field or mid-battle. Re-equip a fresh weapon or fire a REPAIR routine without ever standing still in a dangerous hall.



MENU · STATUS · ITEMS · EQUIP · SKILLS



STATUS · AXIOM'S LIVE READOUT

READING THE READOUT

- LV — chassis level, 1 to 15
- HP — structural integrity
- EN — energy, spent on routines
- ATK / DEF — level + equipped gear
- CREDITS — salvage currency

TURN-BASED COMBAT

Stepping onto grated or infested floor can trip an encounter. The screen swaps to a black arena and the foe is drawn in full — pick **ATTACK**, a **TECH** routine, an **ITEM**, **SCAN**, or **FLEE**.

DAMAGE MODEL

$$\text{HIT} = \max(1, \text{ATK} - \text{DEF} \div 2) + \text{random}(0 \dots \text{ATK} \div 4)$$

Your ATK is your level's power plus your weapon. Your DEF is your level's defense plus armor (and +6 with a WARD chip). Halving the defender's DEF means raw power always gets through — but chipping a high-DEF SENTRY TURRET still rewards a bigger hit.

ENERGY & ROUTINES

Combat routines (TECHs) cost **EN**. SCAN is free and reveals a foe's health; PULSE is your reliable opener; REPAIR trades EN for HP mid-fight. Energy refills on level-up and from Power Cells — spend it, don't hoard it.



ENCOUNTER • A NANITE SWARM INTERCEPTS AXIOM

CREDITS & SALVAGE

Fallen systems drop **credits**. Bank them at the Hub's fabricator for weapons, armor, and cells. Tougher foes on the reactor deck pay far better than the nanites up top — the economy rewards pushing deeper, carefully.

▲ ON GOING OFFLINE

Falling in battle is **not** game over. AXIOM reboots at full HP and EN — but loses **half its credits** in the crash. Death is a tax, not an ending. Spend your salvage **before** a risky push, not after.

◆ THE REPAIR BAY

The Hub's repair bay restores chassis and tops off energy **for free**. Loop back to it between deck runs — it costs nothing but a walk.

SEC.04

THE GROWTH CURVE

EVERY LEVEL, EXACT

Each level raises AXIOM's power, defense, max HP and max EN on a fixed curve, and three combat routines unlock automatically as you climb. The table is transcribed directly from the chassis firmware. XP shown is the total needed to reach the next level.

LV	POWER	DEF	MAX HP	MAX EN	XP → NEXT	UNLOCK
1	6	4	28	10	10	PULSE · SCAN
2	8	5	36	14	28	REPAIR
3	11	7	45	18	60	—
4	14	9	56	24	115	—
5	18	12	68	30	200	OVERLOAD
6	22	15	82	38	330	—
7	27	18	98	46	520	PURGE WAVE
8	33	22	116	56	780	—
9	40	27	136	68	1120	—
10	48	32	158	82	1560	—
11	57	38	182	98	2120	—
12	67	45	206	116	2820	—
13	78	53	226	136	3680	—
14	90	62	240	158	4720	—
15	104	72	252	182	—	MAX

◆ TARGET LEVEL

You can take the WARDEN as early as **LV 7** — the level PURGE WAVE unlocks — if you carry an Aegis Shell, a Ward Chip, and a fistful of Repair Cells. Grinding to **LV 9** on the reactor deck makes the fight comfortable.

■ NOTE

HP is capped at 252 by the chassis's 8-bit integrity register — the curve deliberately tops out just under the ceiling at LV 15.

WEAPONS – SETS ATK BONUS

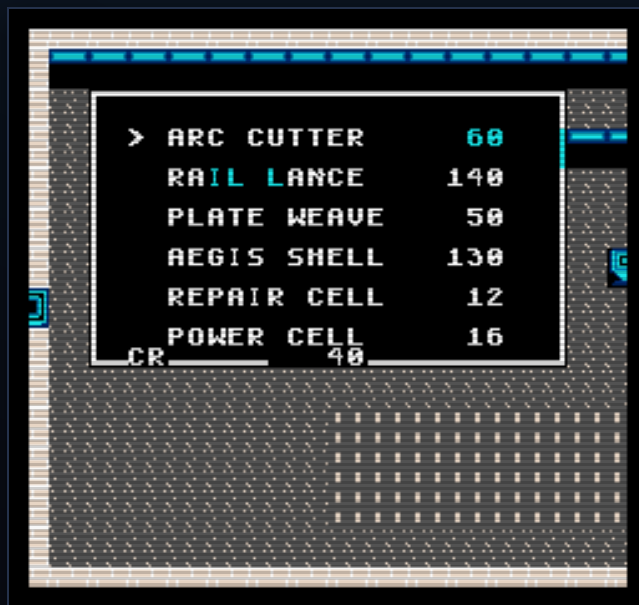
WEAPON	ATK	SOURCE
Servo Fists	+0	Starting
Shock Prod	+6	Salvage
Arc Cutter	+14	Fabricator · 60
Rail Lance	+26	Fabricator · 140

ARMOR – SETS DEF BONUS

ARMOR	DEF	SOURCE
Bare Chassis	+0	Starting
Plate Weave	+8	Fabricator · 50
Aegis Shell	+18	Fabricator · 130

CHIPS – NEURAL CO-PROCESSORS

CHIP	EFFECT	SOURCE
Focus Chip	Targeting aid	Salvage
Ward Chip	+6 DEF	Salvage



FABRICATOR · THE HUB VENDOR · PRICES IN CREDITS

ITEMS

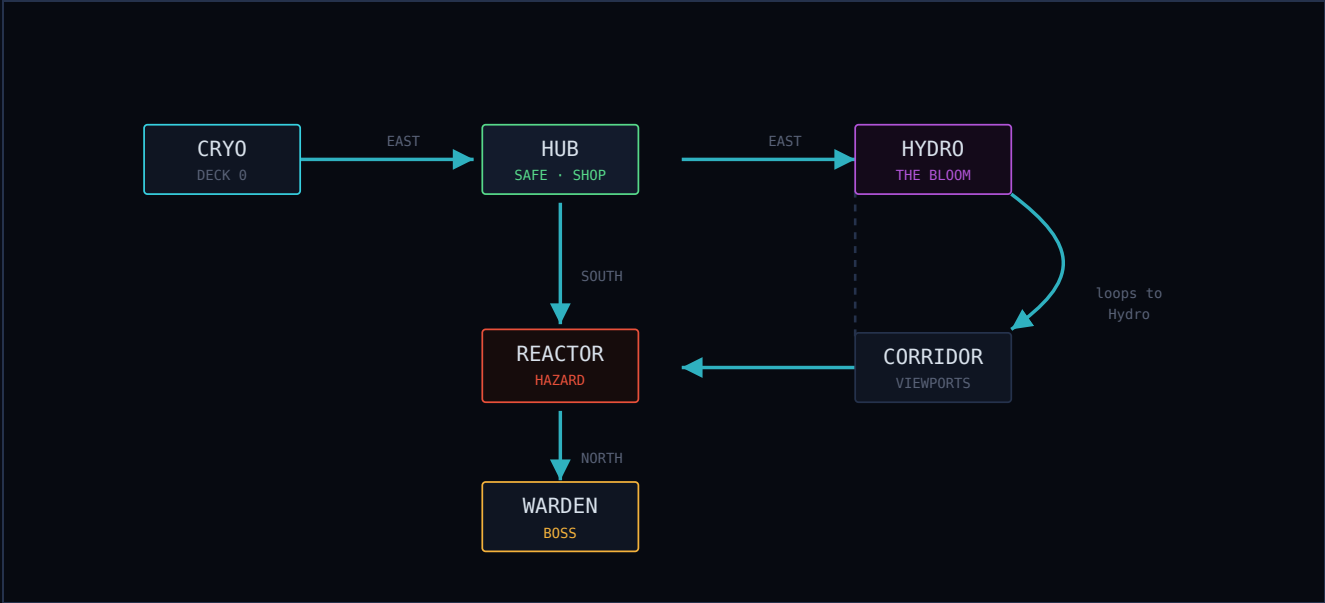
ITEM	EFFECT	BUY
Repair Cell	+40–59 HP	12
Power Cell	+20–29 EN	16
Nano Patch	Full HP	find
Purge Charge	35 dmg to foe	find

ROUTINE	EN	EFFECT	LV
PULSE	3	~10 damage	1
SCAN	0	Reveal foe	1
REPAIR	5	+30 HP	2
OVERLOAD	10	~26 damage	5
PURGE WAVE	8	~18 damage	7

◆ BUY ORDER

Plate Weave first (cheap survival), then Arc Cutter, then save for the **Aegis Shell** before the reactor. Rail Lance last.

The **Erebus** is six connected decks. Doors are one-tile warps between them. The critical path to the WARDEN runs **Cryo** → **Hub** → **Reactor** → **Warden**; Hydroponics and the East Corridor branch off the Hub as grinding and story loops. Numbers below are the destination deck a door leads to.



■ CRITICAL PATH

Cryo (E) → Hub (S) → Reactor (N) → Warden. Four doors from waking to the boss.

◆ WHERE TO GRIND

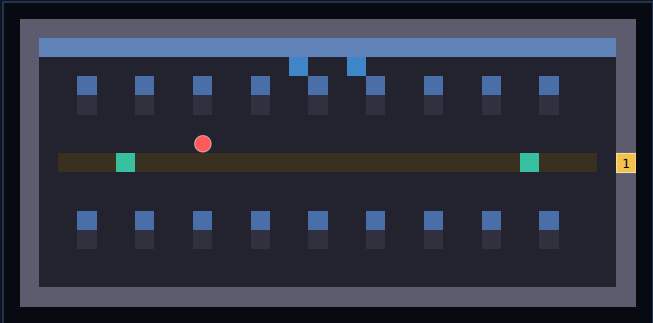
Hydro & Corridor for mid-game credits and XP; the **Reactor** deck for the richest salvage before the descent.

SEC.08

DECK WALKTHROUGH

DECK 0 CRYO BAY

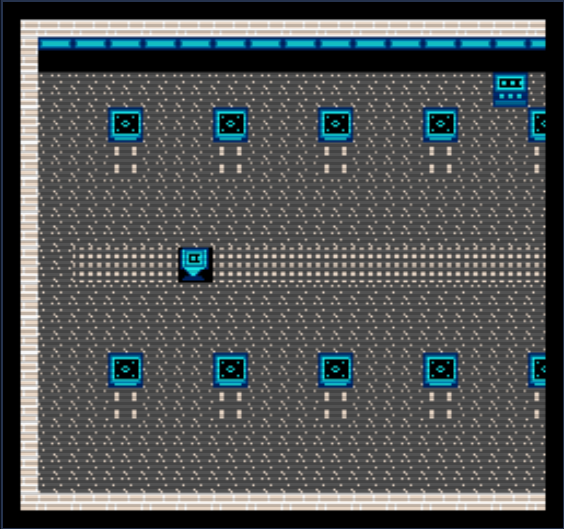
LIGHT THREAT



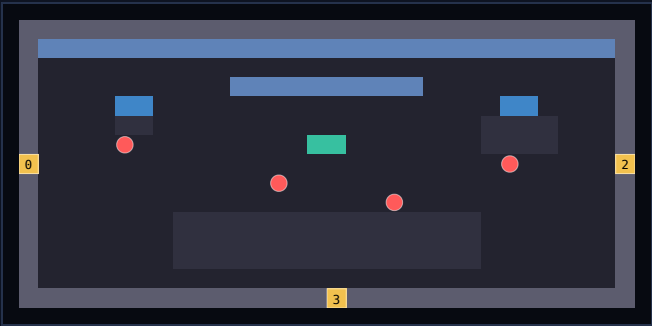
POD GRATE · ENC TERMINAL DOOR NPC

You wake here. Rows of failing cryo-pods line a central grated aisle — and that grating is where nanites and the occasional **Cryo Husk** intercept you. Read the terminals for the captain's log, then head **east** to the door at the far wall.

- ENEMIES Nanite Swarm · Cryo Husk
- EXIT East door → Hub
- DO Level to 2–3 here; learn REPAIR at LV 2



CRYO BAY · THE PODS AND THE AISLE



■ CONSOLE ■ LIT ■ LOG ■ DOOR ■ CREW

No encounters here — this is home base. The **fabricator** (west consoles) sells gear; the **repair bay** (east) mends you for free; the captain's log terminal sits center. Talk to the **engineer** and **medic** for the ship's story and your marching orders. Three doors lead out.

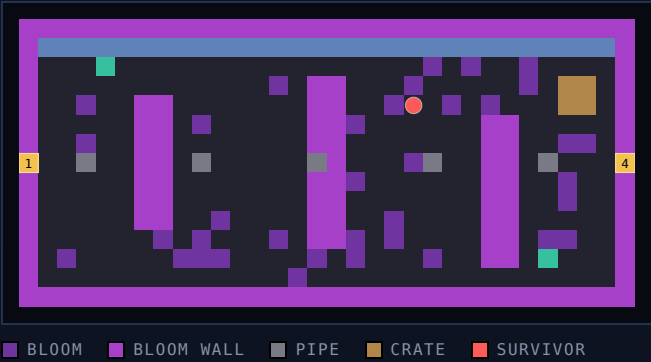
CREW Engineer · Medic · Vendor · Repair tech
WEST → Cryo **EAST** → Hydro **SOUTH** → Reactor
DO Buy Plate Weave + Arc Cutter; bank here between runs

◆ HUB LOOP

Make the Hub your pivot: raid a deck, return to sell/heal, repeat. The free repair bay makes aggressive grinding painless.

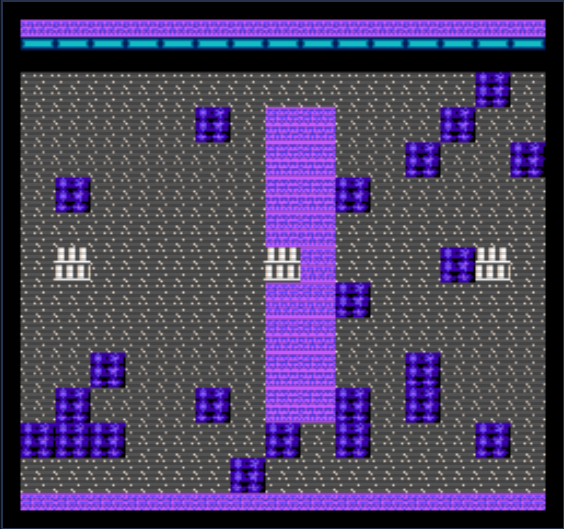
DECK 2 HYDROPONICS · THE BLOOM

MED THREAT



The old garden, wall-to-wall with the **Bloom**. Purple growth chokes the deck and every floor tile can spawn **Bloom Crawlers**, **Cryo Husks**, and **SEC-Drones**. A lone survivor warns you not to linger — good advice, but the credits and XP here fund your Aegis Shell.

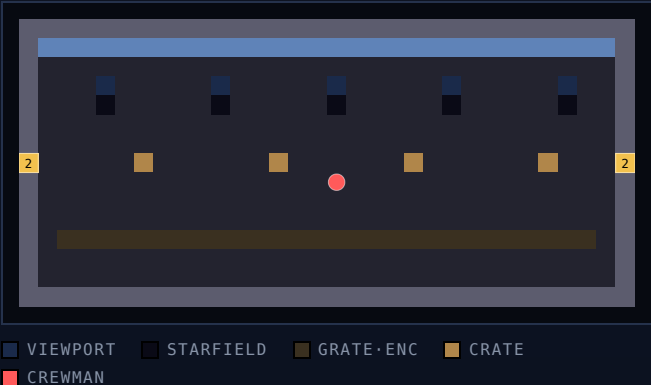
ENEMIES Bloom Crawler · Cryo Husk · SEC-Drone
WEST → Hub **EAST** → Corridor
DO Grind to LV 4–5; grab crates



HYDROPONICS · THE BLOOM HAS THE DECK

DECK 4 EAST CORRIDOR

MED THREAT



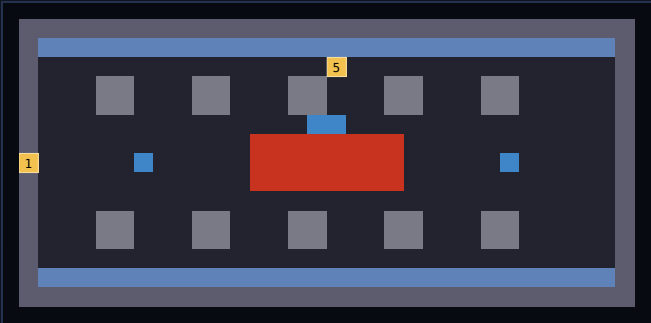
A quiet run of viewports looking out on real, cold stars, where one crewman simply stands and watches. Both of its doors loop back to Hydroponics, so the corridor is an optional pocket — worth the visit for the crate salvage and the same mid-tier foes.

ENEMIES Bloom Crawler · Cryo Husk · SEC-Drone
BOTH DOORS → Hydro (dead-end loop)
DO Optional: salvage & story

* **THE WATCHER**
"STARS. REAL STARS OUT THERE. I FORGOT THEY WERE SO COLD."

DECK 3 REACTOR

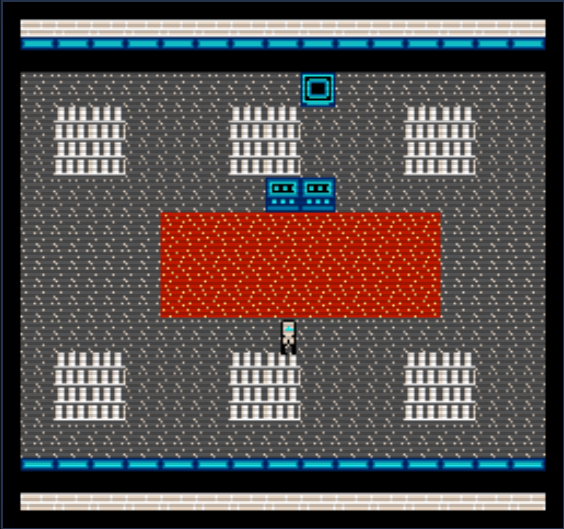
HIGH THREAT



HAZARD CORE PIPE CAGE CONSOLE DOOR

The cold sun-core, ringed by a glowing hazard field and pipe cages. This is the richest — and deadliest — deck: SEC-Drones, high-defense Sentry Turrets, and Warden Nodes that pay the best XP in the ship. Kit out fully before you come here, then take the north door to the WARDEN.

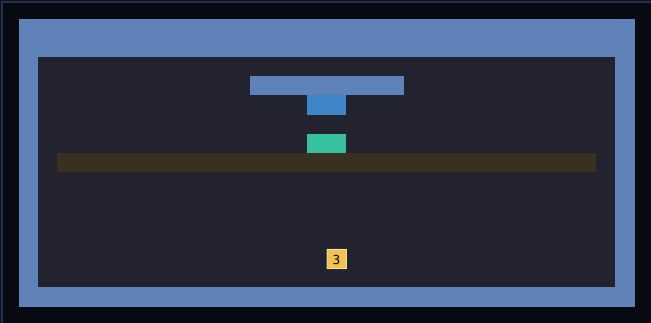
ENEMIES SEC-Drone • Sentry Turret • Warden Node
 WEST → Hub NORTH → Warden Chamber
 DO Grind to LV 7–9; then descend



REACTOR • THE HAZARD CORE

DECK 5 WARDEN CHAMBER

BOSS



LIT CONSOLE TERMINAL DOOR

A lit approach to the core's guardian. Walk up the chamber and the WARDEN wakes — there is no encounter roll here, only the fight. Come in at full HP/EN with Repair Cells stocked. Full strategy on the next page.

BOSS THE WARDEN
 SOUTH → Reactor (retreat)
 DO Save nothing — spend it all

NO TURNING BACK MID-FIGHT

Approaching the top of the chamber triggers the boss automatically. Prepare on the reactor deck, not in the doorway.

HP · ATK · DEF · XP · CR transcribed from combat telemetry. Threat bar scales to the WARDEN. Every foe here is drawn from background tiles in its own palette.



NANITE SWARM

◆ CRYO BAY

HP	ATK	DEF	XP	CR
12	7	3	4	5

THREAT

A cloud of loose maintenance nanites. Harmless one at a time — a basic ATTACK ends it. Your LV 1–2 sparring partner.



SEC-DRONE

◆ HYDRO · CORRIDOR · REACTOR

HP	ATK	DEF	XP	CR
20	11	6	8	10

THREAT

A patrol drone still running its security loop. Quick and moderately armored; PULSE softens it before you swing.



BLOOM CRAWLER

◆ HYDRO · CORRIDOR

HP	ATK	DEF	XP	CR
26	14	5	12	8

THREAT

Bloom made mobile — soft-shelled but it hits hard. Good XP for the credits. PURGE CHARGE, when you find one, wrecks it.



CRYO HUSK

◆ CRYO · HYDRO · CORRIDOR

HP	ATK	DEF	XP	CR
34	18	9	18	14

THREAT

A sleeper the pods couldn't save. Heavy hitter for its depth — keep HP above its ATK and heal early. Do not fight two at low level.



SENTRY TURRET

◆ REACTOR

HP	ATK	DEF	XP	CR
44	22	16	24	20

THREAT

The wall of the reactor: highest DEF short of the boss. Raw power beats it — OVERLOAD punches through where light hits bounce.



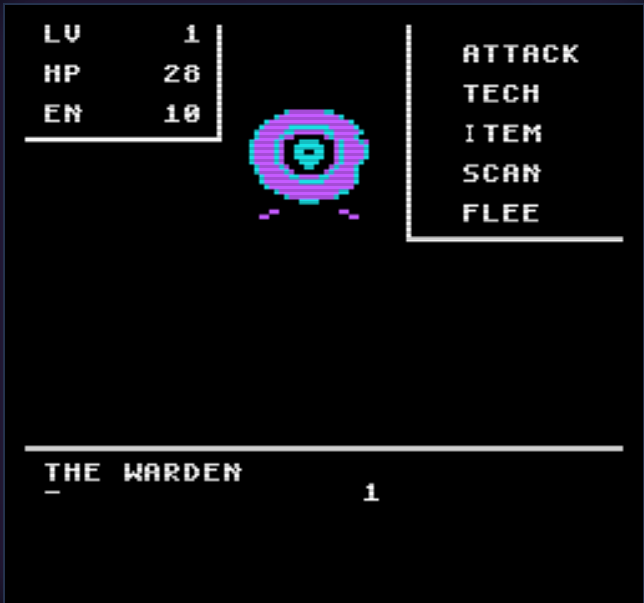
WARDEN NODE

◆ REACTOR

HP	ATK	DEF	XP	CR
40	20	10	30	26

THREAT

A shard of the WARDEN's will. Best XP and credits in the ship — farm these to LV 9 and the boss becomes routine.



THE WARDEN • GUARDIAN OF THE SUN-CORE

HP	ATK	DEF	XP
180	30	18	200

THREAT MAX

* WHAT IT IS

The ship's guardian intelligence — your opposite number. It shut the sun-core to starve the Bloom and has kept the ship in merciful darkness for 900 years. It is not evil. It is a caretaker that chose silence over risk, and never let go.

BEFORE YOU DESCEND

LEVEL 7 minimum • 9 ideal
WEAPON Rail Lance (+26) or Arc Cutter (+14)
ARMOR Aegis Shell (+18) + Ward Chip (+6)
PACK 4+ Repair Cells • Power Cells • any Purge Charge

THE FIGHT

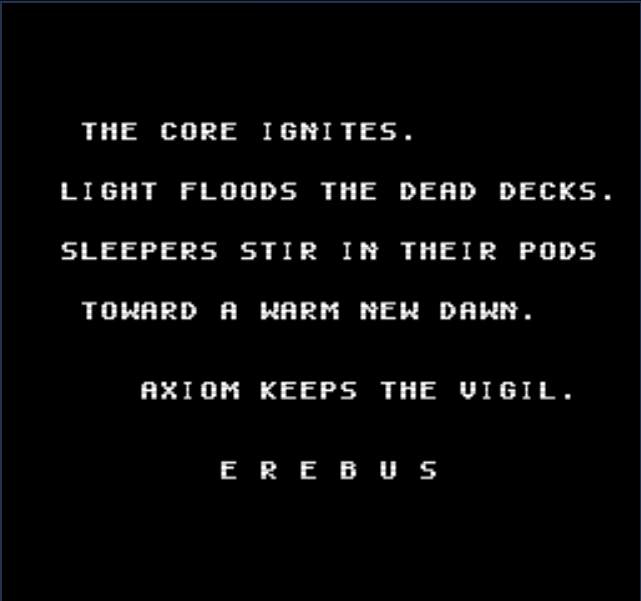
With Aegis + Ward at LV 8, your DEF sits near 46, so the WARDEN's ATK 30 lands for only single digits — a war of attrition you win. Open with **SCAN** to watch its 180 HP fall, then cycle **OVERLOAD** (≈17–23 a hit through DEF 18) and heavy **ATTACK**s. Drop a **Purge Charge** for a free 35. Fire **REPAIR** or a Repair Cell whenever HP dips below one of its hits — never gamble the turn.

MATH

OVERLOAD $\text{dmg} \approx 26 - 9 + \text{rnd}(0-6) \approx 17-23$. ~9 clean hits end it. Incoming $\approx 30 - 23 = 7$ (+small). You out-trade it every round.

♦ IF YOU FALL

Going offline here only costs half your credits and sends you back to reboot — the WARDEN's HP resets, but so does yours, and your levels stay. Re-arm and walk back up.



ENDING · THE CORE IGNITES

⚠ SPOILER

This section reveals the ending. Turn back now if you want to bring the light home yourself.

When the WARDEN falls, its grip on the reactor fails, and AXIOM does the one thing the guardian never dared: it lets the light back in.

■ FINAL SEQUENCE

THE CORE IGNITES.
LIGHT FLOODS THE DEAD DECKS.
SLEEPERS STIR IN THEIR PODS
TOWARD A WARM NEW DAWN.
AXIOM KEEPS THE VIGIL.

EREBUS

The sun-core burns again. Warmth spreads deck by deck to the failing pods, and the sixty sleepers the medic counted begin, at last, to wake. AXIOM does not sleep. It takes up the watch the WARDEN abandoned — not to keep the ship in the dark, but to keep it in the light.

The Bloom is not "cured" — it is simply no longer starved into a nightmare. The garden gets its sun back. So does the crew. That is the whole of AXIOM's mercy, and the difference between it and the WARDEN.

◇ END OF LINE ◇

APX

QUICK REFERENCE

TEAR-OUT CARD

ROUTE TO THE CORE

CRYO →east→ HUB →south→ REACTOR →north→ WARDEN.
Branches: HUB →east→ HYDRO →east→ CORRIDOR (loops back).

SHOP PRIORITIES

- 1 · Plate Weave – 50
- 2 · Arc Cutter – 60
- 3 · Aegis Shell – 130
- 4 · Rail Lance – 140
- + Repair Cells – 12 each, always

ROUTINE UNLOCKS

- LV 1 · PULSE, SCAN
- LV 2 · REPAIR
- LV 5 · OVERLOAD
- LV 7 · PURGE WAVE

COMBAT RULES OF THUMB

HIT = max(1, ATK – DEF/2) + rnd(0..ATK/4)
SCAN is free – always open with it on a new foe
Death = revive full HP, –half credits (not fatal)
Repair Bay in the Hub heals free

BOSS CHECKLIST

- Level 7–9
- Aegis Shell + Ward Chip
- Rail Lance
- 4+ Repair Cells
- Full HP/EN before the north door

DEEP SIGNAL PRESS

RECOVERED SYSTEMS SERIES · EREBUS · MMXXVI

EREBUS and all game systems, art, story, and music were built from scratch in 6502 assembly for the NES. This manual was assembled from the game's own data.

END
KEEP THE
VIGIL